

Tapas Around the World

Tapas distill all of Spanish cuisine into perfect little snacks, making the nibbling of small savories while drinking into a casual feast. The Spanish penchant for two-bite dining and its associated conviviality has swept the world, bringing Iberian dishes along for the ride.

ALICANTE

El Cisne de Oro inexpensive

Calle César Elguezábal 23; www.elcisnedeoro.com

This tile-encrusted traditional bar with hams hanging overhead captures the tastes of both land and sea — slices of mountain ham sit alongside plates of white anchovies in olive oil. The kitchen's own pungent aioli enlivens both the potato salad and small rolls stuffed with pork and mushrooms.

Nou Manolín Restaurante & Bar moderate

Calle Villegas 3; www.noumanolin.com

One of the quintessential tapas spots, not just in Alicante but in all of Spain, Nou Manolín offers more than 50 different tapas every day in the ground-level

bar. All the classics are available, as are dishes with a modern twist, from shrimp in a spicy garlic sauce to sushi-grade slices of fresh red tuna.

La Taberna del Gourmet expensive

Calle San Fernando 10; www.latabernadelgourmet.com

The owners of this pioneer gastrobar are fanatical about sourcing the best fish, vegetables, fruits, and meats and playing up the perfection of the produce. Excellent tapas choices include a fresh tomato salad with tuna belly or tempura-fried baby squid.

GRANADA

Granada's restaurants and bars offer Spain's most generous free tapas, making tapas-hopping an inexpensive way to dine. Dishes might escalate from potato salad to a small dish of stew as customers keep ordering drinks.

Bar Casa Julio inexpensive

Calle Hermosa, just off Plaza Nueva (no telephone)

There's no telling just how old Casa Julio might be, but the jam-packed bar looks little changed from the days before the Spanish Civil War. Specialty tapas here include several variations on octopus and squid — always best with red wine.

Below Bars groaning with tapas dishes welcome workers at the end of the day all over Spain **Bottom left** Air-dried *jamón serrano*, one of Spain's finest delicacies, is often hung from the ceiling

Right (top to bottom) *Gambas* (shrimp) from the grill with, in the background, marinated artichokes; tapas are always best shared, preferably with good red wine; a modern tapas bar in London



On the Menu

Albóndigas Meatballs that combine bread crumbs with pork, veal, lamb, or some combination of meats. They are served in either a brown sauce or a tomato sauce.

Almejas Clams served in the shells, often steamed with wine, herbs, and vegetables.

Anchoas The small Spanish white anchovies, usually lightly poached and preserved in olive oil.

Berenjenas rebozadas A dish with North African origins, consisting of eggplant that is salted, breaded, and fried in olive oil.

Boquerones Anchovies, either canned in vinegar or fresh and deep-fried.

Chorizo A distinctive Spanish sausage with many regional variations. It usually contains pieces of cured ham as well

as ground pork and is always strongly flavored with Spanish paprika.

Croquetas These take many forms but most often feature minced cured ham or poached tuna. In both cases, the filling is blended with béchamel sauce, rolled in fine crumbs, and deep-fried in olive oil.

Gambas Shrimp or prawns (species can vary by season): served *a la plancha*, they are grilled whole with the heads on; *gambas al ajillo* are peeled shrimp that are fried in olive oil with copious quantities of fresh garlic.

Jamón serrano The air-dried mountain hams seen hanging from the ceilings of tapas bars, so concentrated and intense that servings are sliced paper-thin.

Morcilla A blood sausage or black pudding. As a tapa, it is usually sliced, fried in olive oil, and served with toothpicks.

In northern Spain, it is filled with pork fat, rice, and onions, but in central and southern Spain the filler usually includes bread crumbs and almonds.

Patatas bravas Named for the Madrid bar that invented them, fried potatoes served with a dip of paprika-laced aioli (a very garlicky, mayonnaise-like sauce).

Pimientos rellenos Stuffed peppers: there are a number of varieties, the most common being small triangular peppers from the north (either green or red) filled with salt cod and whipped potato.

Queso manchego The famous aged sheep's milk cheese of La Mancha, usually sliced very thin and served in triangles.

Tortilla española Perhaps the most universal dish in Spain, a masterful combination of fried potatoes baked into a thick omelet, sliced and often eaten cold.